

My friend Chuck is a senior architect in a fifty-person firm in Saint Louis. The firm's two partners each make upward of \$100,000, while Chuck struggles along at \$35,000. What are the chances of Chuck's becoming a partner and breaking into the big time?

"Until about six months ago the chances were pretty good," Chuck told me. "I was spending three hours a day on staffing and office work. The partners were thinking of admitting me to the firm as administrative partner. But I hate office work. After two years of it I insisted on going back to the creative side full-time. I don't think I'll ever make partner on the creative side, but I'm happier now. I drive home after work feeling good about myself rather than tired and mad."

I respect Chuck's decision. Chuck is a jovial, easygoing guy who leaves the office promptly at six each day. He has an adorable wife and three small children who mean more to him than anything he could possibly do at the office. He's 30 years old and wants to enjoy these next few years—on the job *and* at home.

But what makes good sense for Chuck at age 30 may leave him feeling stale and useless at age 35. His children will be older and will want more time of their own. Family life will go more smoothly, leaving Chuck more energy for other things. And, most important, Chuck may change his views about what type of work he enjoys. In five years the *creative* side may leave him sapped. Chuck may want to take on a new office project. Chuck loves to work with computers, for example. If the office continues to grow, Chuck may be just the man to program a computer to do staffing, scheduling, and related tasks.

When was the last time you reevaluated career decisions you made ten, five, or even three years ago? You hated sales, but are you sure you'd hate sales now? You panicked at the thought of running your own business, but would you panic now? You stewed over people problems, but you're more